

Confronting Destiny

Having joined the league at a very young age, Jennifer Lawrence struggled mightily in her first few years. Before long, the questions started to mount. Was she not getting the training she needed, or did she just not have what it takes to compete at this level? When her previous stable folded up, Danni and I decided RSI should be the group to find out.

How did we make our decision?

First thing we look for is solid fundamentals. Forget theatrics and popularity and signature fighting styles. This is about boring stuff like footwork and punching technique and always being mindful of your defense. The little things every fighter needs to do to win. Jen gave us no reason for concern in those areas.

But not everything is about how well you can punch or how much pain you can take. In large part, it comes down to how well you handle the ride. One night, you just can't miss. Everything you do is working, you're reading your opponent like a book and winning comes easily. A few months later, you're the one getting worked over and beaten senseless.

Those sharp ups and downs can take an emotional toll. A toll that is too high for many. Questions and doubts begin to flood your mind. Success quickly becomes harder to come by.

So, that was the thing that really attracted us to J-Law. Her ability to roll with the punches is known far and wide. Is she confident? Absolutely. But she is also pragmatic. When she joined us, she was just about flat in the win and loss columns. The definition of mediocrity. But it was the flatness of her ego that drew our interest. She knows she isn't perfect, and she's very willing to admit to her flaws. An essential step toward getting them fixed. She also understands that holding on to a loss gets her nowhere. Examine it. Learn from it. Then put it behind you. Jen does that as well as anyone I know.

In many ways, she reminds me of another young RSI fighter. One who joined us right about that same time. One who has since risen to become one of our most beloved champions... along with being a well-intentioned thorn in my side.

Both Jen and Emma have plenty of reason to boast. Each has achieved and experienced things outside the cage that most never get close to. So, why don't they act like they're better than everyone else? Because it simply isn't in them. They're not wired that way.

Inside the cage, Jen hasn't experienced the kind of meteoric rise Emma has. I don't know exactly how to account for that. Is she not as good? Is her division tougher? Could be either, neither or both. But I do know this... since joining RSI, she has been able to do the one thing that defines success at the most basic level. She wins more than she loses. Her rise has been tortuously slow compared to Emma's, but it has been steady and constant. And she's close enough now to glimpse the top. Not only did she have the chance to do something special here tonight, but she was also nearing a shot at the divisional crown. If she gets there - and I have no doubt that she will - she will have already earned the kind of respect Emma is still hunting for. Simply because of the effort she had to put into the climb.

So it was no surprise to me that Jen looked no different than usual as she strode into the arena here in Perth. No fear. No showboating. She took the time to interact with the crowd along the way, but there was no conceit in it. She truly appreciated her fans, and they loved her for it.

The crowd in general, though, was saving its love for Josie Maran. The darling of the tournament. Not just because of what she'd done here, but because her story was even more compelling than Jen's. What could be more riveting than a long, arduous climb to the top? How about doing it twice?

Josie had once been the divisional champion... frequently doing battle with none other than Danni early in their careers. A rules change moved Josie to a different weight class before that rivalry really got hot, but a host of other problems took Josie out of contention shortly thereafter. Injuries and tough losses had her free-falling through the rankings. She tried to claw her way back, but couldn't find the support she needed. Financial difficulties had shuttered not one but two stables right out from under her. She was quickly forgotten. Put out to pasture in favor of new names and younger faces.

But now that she had latched on with *Dragon's Den*, the tumult had quieted. She was back in a place where the distractions were few and the support was constant. Where it was all about her skills and what she did in the cage. And without a doubt, she was proving she still had it. A long chain of victories had carried her back to the top, and she had only recently put the divisional belt back in her trophy case after tearing it from the clutches of the vaunted Malin Akerman. Then she came here and swatted not only Britney, but the practically unbeatable Doutzen Kroes. Now, she was one win away from adding her first tournament title to her trophy case.

As the bell sounded, all I could think was, *Good luck, Jen. You're going to need it.*

The first minute saw little action as the fighters felt each other out. Jen was the first to get serious... pressing forward behind a furious combination. Josie weathered the storm easily, then countered with a solid uppercut that found its mark.

It was the sort of thing you usually see much later in the fight. After the fighters have been grinding it out for a while and fatigue has set in. Maybe you notice your opponent is getting sloppy with her defense, so you put one right on the point of her chin. Launching it early is usually just a waste of energy work because your opponent is fresh and alert. But not for Josie. Not in this tournament. Everything she tried seemed to be working, and this was no exception... with the video revealing the damage included a little blood trickling from the corner of Jen's mouth.

Josie's first big punch was a sort of reckless shot in the dark that not only connected, but drew blood. Perfect.

Josie surged forward, going to the body as she looked to capitalize. Jen showed her poise, gathering herself quickly and circling out of trouble.

Josie continued to press forward. Jen tried to slow the advance with a low kick, but Maran checked it and powered through Jen's defense with a straight right hand that found its mark.

Jen was momentarily staggered. By the time she got her bearings, Josie had pulled her into a loose clinch.

J-Law battled back, and there was a brief pushing and shoving contest as the two fought for position. Josie used the chaos to try a quick heel trip, but the takedown attempt resulted in a little stumble for Jen and that was all.

Or was it?

Again, Josie took advantage of the situation... snaking her hands up behind Jen's head before she regained her balance and locking in the Muay Thai clinch.

Now in firm control, Josie started to get her licks in. Nothing that looked particularly bad. No prolonged series of vicious strikes or complex combinations. Mostly, it looked like some sort of oddly contentious waltz as the two grappled for position. But getting the early advantage let Josie do more as the dance continued. Pushing Jen off to hammer home a knee strike, then pulling her back in tight to prevent retaliation. Chipping away at the younger fighter with quick punches and short elbows that Jen could do little to avoid. The kind of stuff that adds up fast and saps your energy the longer it goes on. And this one went on forever. Thirty-plus seconds of clock time that felt like an eternity before Jen finally swam an arm inside and got the leverage she needed to twist her way free.

The two reset again, and Jen quickly made it clear she was tired of taking but not giving. A feint with the jab got Josie's guard up and her eyes looking that way. Lawrence pivoted and launched the right leg at the brunette's exposed side. No luck. Josie swept her left arm down and knocked the kick aside. The block stole some of Jen's balance. For a moment, the door was wide open, and Josie happily made herself welcome.

A right hand pounded into Jen's side. She tried to clinch, but Josie immediately pushed her off. The Den fighter launched a quick flurry, but Jen backed out of range. Josie followed and caught her near the fence. There was a fierce exchange, with Josie seemingly getting the better of it.

That was the theme so far. While neither fighter was necessarily dominating, everything seemed to be leaning Josie's way.

The fighters closed again. Josie fired off the one, two. Jen guarded both, then responded with a jab of her own. Josie slipped it and scored with a big right hand to the body. The pain showed through on Jen's face, but she shot the jab again and circled away before more damage could be done.

Again they closed. Josie wanted to get inside, but Jen made good use of her jab to maintain distance. Maran was forced to back out and rethink her approach.

Jen didn't follow, and I realized that was also becoming a theme. One I wasn't happy to see. While no one on the RSI roster employs the all-or-nothing, kamikaze fight strategy, Jen is among the fighters who like a quicker tempo. Taking the battle one exchange at a time was not her style. She liked to get her offense going and then keep it going... applying a constant, steady pressure that wore her opponent down and

allowed little room to make adjustments. But Jen wasn't finding her rhythm here, and the problem - if you want to call it that - was Josie.

No one can really explain what *the zone* is, but athletes from every sport on the planet will tell you it exists. It's a place where you can seemingly do no wrong. No advanced training program is required to get there. No new techniques or strategies need to be deployed. You just suddenly start doing the things you'd always done better than you'd done them before, and every chance you take seems to work out.

With Akerman, Spears and Kroes in her wake, there was no doubt Josie Maran was in that zone.

So what was Jen to do? She had tried patience, but slowing the action simply allowed Josie to pick her spots - which she was doing very effectively. When Lawrence tried to take the initiative, Maran brushed her aside like it was nothing and then gave her a quick beating.

The fight was only about two and a half minutes old, but it already felt like Jen had lost. Like it was just a matter of time before Josie put the cherry on this sundae.

The fighters closed again. Maran pushed forward behind a barrage of punches, but not much damage was done. Jen jabbed and circled and just plain stayed out of harm's way.

That cycle repeated itself. More circling and jabbing, but no engagement from Jen. Strategically, it was an improvement, but not much of one. She was doing a great job of staying on the move, and this was certainly better than getting her ass kicked. But it wasn't going to win her the fight.

Josie pushed harder. Using the jab and some footwork of her own to try and cut off the ring. It was largely ineffective. Her defense may not have been rock solid and her offense was obviously sputtering, but Jen's ring awareness was on point. Whenever Maran tried to close, Lawrence would jab her off and circle away. Josie tried some different approaches and angles, but Jen was keen to all of them. Josie kept coming. Not reckless, but not tentative. Maintaining an even, steady pressure that kept her no more than step or two behind Lawrence. The overall effect made it look like Jen was leading her opponent around on a string.

In the end, she led her right into disaster.

With just under a minute and half to go, Jen circled around to the center of the ring and let Josie close. Then she gave the older brunette what she wanted. Instead of backing out, she stood and traded punches. After a minute of chasing her opponent around, Josie wasn't ready for it. They traded jabs, with Jen's connecting while Josie's fell short. Jen fired the right hand without delay. Solid contact. Josie took the full force, then slid right to get away. Straight into a wicked left hook from the *Hunger Games* actress.

Josie stumbled. That one made an impression. But she quickly gathered herself, coming up with a knowing smirk and a little head bob. As if to say, *Alright... you got me with that one.*

But Jen wasn't waiting around for an atta-girl. Knowing she had done damage, she kicked it into high gear. The one-two wiped the smile of Josie's face. She retreated, and Jen stayed with her. Bobbing and weaving. Firing off combinations from different angles. Changing elevations. Josie kept backing away. Instinct told

her that couldn't continue. She was going to run out of room. But when? It's hard to keep track of your position when you're getting pummeled. Your vision is skewed. You're steps are not measured. You're movement is about survival, not strategy. How far from the fence was she? Chances were good that Josie had no clue.

So, what to do?

Option one... make a stand. Plant your feet and fire back. Make your opponent stop and defend herself. The simple and obvious answer that was not at all simple to do. Trying to back out of harm's way is how you got in this mess. Wouldn't stopping put you IN harm's way? A big risk to take, especially when you didn't know how much room you had. What if you went toe-to-toe, only to get thumped and then shoved into the cage anyway?

Option two... let the fence come. No doubt a dangerous move, but one that had merit. Being trapped against the mesh would be a disaster, but it would also immediately get you reoriented and back on track as far as knowing where you were. The trick was in the reaction time. You had to find the fence, fire off some punches and bounce out of there before the other girl pinned you down. Not three consecutive steps, but one continuous motion.

Whether by choice or by force, that's what Josie tried. She did it all right, and she did it all fast. She hit the mesh, and immediately sent out a vicious volley. Not well-targeted, but completely overwhelming. The kind of thing Jen would have to back away from. Then Maran slid left... and Jen pounded her fist right into the center of her face.

It was a long, clean strike, thrown almost before Josie made her move. Like Jen knew what was going to happen and aimed for the spot where Maran's head would be. How did she know? I'd be willing to bet she guessed and got lucky. Josie was in some trouble, and Jen knew she would fight like hell to get out of it. That left two options for Lawrence. Play it smart and back way, or plunge into the storm and take her chances.

There was no real plus to the latter, but the first option offered a little bonus. Skipping the wild skirmish allowed Jen to focus on what would come next. After all, there were only two directions for Josie to go. Left or right. Fifty-fifty are pretty good odds, so Jen picked one and took her shot.

Josie threw her hands up in front of her as she rocked back into the cage. Jen looped a left hook around the meager guard. Solid hit. Josie shifted her defense that way, and another right hand found its way to her chin.

Maran was in real trouble now. She kept her defense up and tried firing her jab to make some space. She found some success, but it did little more than slow the assault. Lawrence still had the clearer view. It was easier for her to make adjustments. The punches kept coming. High and low. Inside and outside. Josie retreated into a defensive shell. Making herself harder to hit, but easier to control. Jen started picking her shots. The ref was on alert. For a few precious seconds, it looked like it might be over.

Then Josie started with the kicks.

Low, short kicks, thrown blindly. Totally defensive, but also effective. There were no real impacts, but there was a sloppy sort of entanglement. Her legs occupying space Jen needed for her own movement. It messed with Lawrence's balance and screwed up her angles. She didn't know quite how to adjust, which forced her to regroup. That was all Josie needed. She shot out the jab then got her hands into Jen's chest and pushed her back. Already off-balance, Jen was forced to retreat.

It was a veteran move from a veteran fighter. A smart play by Jen had put Josie in a bad situation, but this wasn't a shootout. There was no rule that said she had to counter with an even stronger attack. If a little wily positioning got the job done, that was good enough.

Sometimes success in the cage is about power and violence. Sometimes it's just about living through the next ten seconds.

The final minute ticked off with no significant damage done. A few short, even skirmishes, and that was it.

Both fighters turned for their respective corners without so much as a glance at each other. Neither seemed angry. They were just busy. Both needed counsel and medical attention. They needed every second of this break they could get.

Jen had spent the better part of the round on her back foot, and there was no chance Josie was going to make it easier for her in the second. Did she need a new plan, or just better execution? I wasn't sure, but I was certain she needed a healthy helping of encouragement at the very least. No problem there. As the seconds streamed in, I could clearly make out Leesh's perky blonde head bounding right along with the others.

Need strategy? Steph is there for you.

Got wounds that need tending? Marcy the magician, at your service.

But if you need a shot in the arm, there is no better choice than Elisha. It's not that she knows how to help, exactly. A scrapper all the way, she's practically useless from a tactical perspective. But she does bring with her the power of positivity.

Sound stupid? I couldn't agree more, but the results speak for themselves.

Leesh is not the rainbows and bubbles type. She is not a vibrant sunbeam in a bottle. She is simply selectively ignorant. She will not let you be down on yourself. Negative thinking is not permitted. Bad things are invisible. Your blood could literally be pooling on the canvas beneath you, and Elisha won't even notice. That's a product of what happened before, and Leesh is all about what comes next.

I'm not going to lie. It's maddening to experience. No... it's flat out crazy. Her happy little blonde face talking at you like nothing is wrong. Like she was living in some alternate dimension where the beating you just took never happened. But it works. She sells nothing but upside, and she sells it hard. You could be

flat out getting your ass kicked with no logical hope in sight, and you'd still be thinking you could knock down walls with your bare hands by the time Leesh was done with you.

Luckily, nothing so drastic was needed here. The opener had not been great, but nowhere near a disaster. That surge toward the end would give Elisha plenty of material to work with. She'd have Jen thirsty for more in short order.

The mood was about the same on the other side of the cage, for the exact opposite reasons. A round that had been firmly in Josie's pocket had been thrown into uncertainty in a span of less than thirty seconds. On top of that, questions were starting to form. Riding in on a wave of dominance, Josie's victory had seemed a sure thing before this started. Now, a big chunk had been torn out of that confidence. Was it time for despair? Not hardly, but it was clear that whatever mojo had carried Josie this far put no quake in Jen's boots. This one was going to be a battle.

The big question: had Jen's short but brutal outburst stolen the round? I honestly couldn't say for sure. While it was easily the biggest moment, Josie had pretty much owned the rest of the frame.

There was no way to guess which way the judges would lean when a round was that close, which means you have to assume you lost it for strategy purposes. Not encouraging, but not really a big deal. Especially this early. Odds were good that whatever decided this thing would happen in the rounds to come, not the one that had just passed.

That's the way it usually works. Someone takes control and begins to impart her will on her opponent. Even when there is no definitive finish, there is normally a clear winner.

The way it usually works... only this fight turned out far from usual.

Did Jen finally get her offense on track and pound Maran into oblivion? Nope.

Did Josie resume her dominance and fulfill the destiny she had been... uh... destined for? Also no.

What happened was that war broke out. An all-out, take-no-prisoners war between two fighters who would not give an inch.

The two wasted no time getting to it. The first exchange of the second round saw Josie score with a solid right hand only seconds before Jen answered with one of her own. The next exchange saw Jen get inside and land a brilliant combination to Maran's body. Then Josie tagged her with a left hook as she tried to get back out.

The back-and-forth continued, with a lot of punishment handed out by both fighters. Some exchanges went Josie's way. Others went to Jen. Lawrence landed another combination near the middle of the round, then chased a reeling Josie to the fence. The two clinched and grappled, with Jen maintaining control and methodically working Maran over. Finally, it looked like someone was going to take charge. But Josie soon managed to work her hands free. Some pushing and shoving - and another nifty little trip move - and the

next thing you know she'd spun Jen around and reversed their positions. Jen got out of it, but not before Josie had spent a half-minute or so exacting some revenge.

And so it went. Josie was still living in that zone she'd started in, but whatever Kool-Aid she'd drunk to get her there... somebody had smuggled a cup or two over to Jen. Despite the fact that both were technically sharp, defense seemed almost useless. Both were hitting with almost everything they threw.

When the round ended, I was again left with no clear way to determine a winner.

It only got worse from there. As the fight wore on, the physical toll added up on both warriors. The sharpness faded. Posture suffered. Defense wilted. Each fighter had her moments. Each suffered at the hands of her rival. It became a question of who could take more.

The damage continued to mount, and blood started to flow. By the middle of the fourth, the pace had slowed considerably because they just couldn't keep it up anymore. That didn't stop them from trying. Clinching and infighting became the theme. The struggle moved to a game of inches instead of yards. Still, they battled on.

By then I had thrown my scorecard in the trash. Some fights are meant to be witnessed, not analyzed.

The fifth round went down in the same brutal, grinding, even fashion. The final few minutes were pretty much a waste. Just a lot of pushing, shoving and leaning. The women were exhausted. Neither had anything left to give. Despite that, the crowd was on its feet. Everyone has a favorite, but rooting interests were secondary at this point. These people knew what they were witnessing. It was exactly what they'd come to see. Two women who were willing to lay it all on the line.

I don't believe in destiny. I never will. But in the end, the way this one came down made the theory hard to disprove. Neither fighter had really won, though both had done enough to get the victory. Physically, the seesaw battle had taken a heavy toll, leaving both looking like they'd clearly lost.

So, how did the judges decide? Only they know for sure, but my guess is they elected not to mess with the story book narrative. The conventional wisdom said this was Josie's fight to lose, and that really hadn't happened. So, they gave the majority of the fans what they wanted and declared her the winner. Destiny fulfilled.

When the decision was announced, her fans celebrated in the way only sports fans can. Like their fighter had destroyed her opponent on the way to a clear and concise victory.

But a funny thing happened as Jen made her exit. A second, clearly distinct round of cheering started. Were they Jen's fans? Many obviously were, but it steadily grew to be more than that. Slowly but surely, most of the arena stopped to give the runner-up her due. She'd given it her all, and she'd performed like a champion. Though she had no prize to show for it, they wanted to give her the recognition she deserved.

It was a touching moment... and I'm not the kind of person who is easily touched.

Overall, I was left with the feeling that something big had happened for Jennifer tonight. Josie came into this fight with the advantage in experience, hardware and public sentiment. The task set before Jen was roughly the same as trying to stop a speeding bus. Add to that the fact that the fight started to get away from her almost immediately, and it was easy to see how this could have been a disaster. But she never wavered. Never bent or wilted under the pressure... or even acknowledged that there was any. Instead, she reigned things in, fought like an animal and even won the crowd over, to some degree. While the final decision hadn't gone her way, it didn't feel like she was leaving here the loser.

It felt like she now had a destiny of her own to fulfill.